4.5

Consolidation

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Military Diplomacy

Although most of my tenure was under the shadow of the Covid pandemic, we did manage to visit a number of foreign countries under the rubric of defence cooperation. Military cooperation spans a range of activities starting from student exchange programmes to conferences in the form of Subject Matter Expert Exchanges (SMEE) to joint training at the Platoon, Company and Battalion level, and of course, reciprocal visits by senior officers. The visits by the Chief had both a functional and symbolic value through the message it conveyed. My visits to Nepal and Myanmar highlighted the importance of India's 'Neighbourhood First' policy. Each and every foreign visit garnered considerable interest even before the visit actually commenced and helped project the image of our country under the Diplomacy Information Military Economy (DIME) construct. There were always some defining or unique aspects to each of the visits, the nuances of which were noticed by the media. Veena accompanied me on each of

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